

Now let us sit down with Mr. Emerson by candlelight in his book-lined study:

Every act rewards itself, or, in other words, integrates itself in a two-fold manner—first, in the thing, or in real nature; and secondly, in the circumstance, or in apparent nature. Men call the circumstance the retribution. The casual retribution is in the thing, and is seen by the soul. The retribution in the circumstance is seen by the understanding; it is inseparable from the thing, but is often spread over a long time, and so does not become distinct until after many years. The specific stripes may follow late after the offense, but they follow because they accompany it. Crime and punishment grow out of one stem. Punishment is a fruit that unsuspected ripens within the flower of the pleasure which concealed it. Cause and effect, means and ends, seed and fruit, cannot be severed; for the effect already blooms in the cause, the end pre-exists in the means, the fruit in the seed.

Think back upon the story I have told you in detail; the four episodes of success in my life which began at Wooding's in Atlanta. The cause behind those episodes was a simple act of service rendered to a friend I was able to help. It brought me blessings which still continue. Had I substituted for my act of service some selfish or unworthy act, I would not now enjoy those blessings but might still suffer under the penalty which the same Law of Compensation surely would have brought my way.

"There is a third silent party to all our bargains." Remember that! The Sage of Concord continues:

Men suffer all their life long, under the foolish superstition that they can be cheated. But it is as impossible for a man to be cheated by anyone but himself, as for a thing to be, and not to be, at the same time. There is a third silent party to all our bargains. The nature and soul of things takes on itself the guaranty of the fulfillment of every contract, so that honest service cannot come to loss. If you serve an ungrateful master, serve him the more. Put God in your debt. Every stroke shall be repaid. The longer the payment is withholden, the better for you; for compound interest on compound interest is the rate and usage of this exchequer.

The third silent party! There is the unseen force which in its timeless way makes sure of "the fulfillment of every contract" we make with the world. And now let us see how Emerson expresses his understanding of the fact that every adversity carries with it the seed of an equivalent or greater benefit: